

Doctrine

as principle of unity

Three activities for circle work

INTRODUCTION

This booklet proposes three activities for working the theme of *doctrine* within the strategy pentagon, with a specific emphasis: doctrine as what **enables and sustains unity** among those who work pastorally in the face of addictions and recruitment.

The three activities are different and complementary. Each can be used on its own; the full sequence is recommended when at least half a day is available (approximately three and a half hours).

Three misunderstandings the activities work with

When it is claimed that “doctrine unites us,” one of these three reflexes tends to appear in the room. The activities are designed to unsettle them in practice:

1. *“Doctrine unites us because we all think the same.”*

False. It unites because it gives us a common floor from which to think differently. Uniformity is not unity.

2. *“Doctrine unites those of my own tradition.”*

Insufficient. In ecumenical key, doctrine unites precisely in what is common among traditions: the shared is prior to, and larger than, what is proper to each one.

3. *“Doctrine unites us because we all sign on to it.”*

Superficial. It unites when it is practiced, not when it is approved.

Any activity that works must make visible, in real time, these three things: that unity is not uniformity, that it is wider than one’s own tradition, and that it is at stake in practice.

ACTIVITY 1

The circle of fertile divergences

OBJECTIVE	To show that doctrine unites despite internal divergences. Unity is not uniformity.
FORMAT	Circle with a talking piece. No cross-talk during the round.
TIME	30–40 minutes (round + debrief).
MATERIALS	Talking piece; circle seating.
GROUP	8 to 25 people.

Prompt

“Name one thing on which you disagree with someone from your own confessional tradition, but on which doctrine still unites you.”

Procedure

1. Explain the prompt and clarify the circle rule: during the round there is no cross-talk and no reply. Each person speaks while holding the talking piece; the others listen.
2. Complete round. The facilitator may participate or not, depending on their read of the group.
3. At the end of the round, a brief silence of assimilation (one or two minutes).

Debrief

- What did you hear that you weren’t expecting?
- What does what we said reveal about the nature of doctrinal unity?
- Where does doctrine appear as what sustains without uniforming?

Notes for the facilitator

The learning this activity makes visible is twofold: there is more *internal* divergence than we usually recognize, and there is more *underlying* unity than we usually assume. Doctrine shows itself as what withstands difference without breaking.

ACTIVITY 2

The three baskets

OBJECTIVE	To make visible the relative weight between what is shared, what is proper to each tradition, and what is distinctive. To show that we share more than we suppose.
FORMAT	Silent individual work + plenary.
TIME	45–60 minutes.
MATERIALS	Three labeled baskets; sets of cards with doctrinal statements; floor or long-table space.
GROUP	8 to 25 people.

Labeling of the baskets

- **Basket A – Shared.** What is present across the various Christian traditions (and, where applicable, across other faith traditions as well).
- **Basket B – Proper to my tradition.** What I identify as my confession's own, even though I do not reject it in others.
- **Basket C – What distinguishes me.** What marks the specific difference of my tradition from others.

Prompt

"Each person receives a full set of cards. Without conversation for now, place them in the basket you think fits, according to your own criterion. Afterward we will look together at what happened."

Suggested cards

These are initial suggestions; the facilitator may adapt the list to the group's profile. A set of 12 to 18 cards is recommended.

- Dignity of every human person
- Trinitarian baptism
- Option for the poor
- Papal authority
- *Sola scriptura*
- Care of creation
- Real presence in the Eucharist
- Salvation by grace
- Veneration of the saints
- Marriage as a sacrament
- The Trinity as central mystery
- Universal destination of goods
- Bodily resurrection
- Evangelizing mission
- Authority of Sacred Scripture
- Mutual recognition of baptism among churches
- Sacrament of reconciliation
- Universal call to holiness

Procedure

1. Distribute the card sets: one complete set per participant.
2. Each person places their cards in the three baskets, in silence, without watching where the others place theirs.
3. When finished, open the plenary. The facilitator takes out, one at a time, the cards that ended up “moved” — that is, that different people placed in different baskets.
4. Discuss why. The goal is not agreement, but to see the map.
5. At the close, count how many cards ended up predominantly in **Basket A**. Almost always there are considerably more than each participant expected before starting. That finding is the door to the central message.

Debrief

- What surprises came up? Which cards did you think would go to one basket and ended up in another?
- What does the visible balance among the three baskets show?
- What does it imply for shared pastoral work in the face of addictions and recruitment?

Notes for the facilitator

The activity works best when the group is plural in confessional traditions. If the group is homogeneous, the conversation naturally shifts toward the distinction between what is doctrine and what is ecclesial culture: there are almost always crossed surprises, and that shift is also fertile.

ACTIVITY 3

The shared declaration

OBJECTIVE	To produce, in real time, a shared doctrinal declaration in the face of a concrete problem. To show that when the focus is contributing to the world, common doctrine appears quickly and with force.
FORMAT	Small mixed groups + plenary.
TIME	45–60 minutes.
MATERIALS	Sheets of paper, pens; tables or comfortable spaces for small groups; a large sheet or board for the plenary.
GROUPS	3 to 4 people per group, mixed by confessional tradition.

Prompt

"In 20 minutes, write a shared declaration — no more than five lines — on why faith communities have something distinctive to contribute in the face of the problem of addictions and recruitment. You may include only what the three or four of you would sign without hesitation."

Procedure

1. Group formation. The facilitator actively ensures that each group has different confessional traditions. If the group is homogeneous, organize by generations, countries, pastoral sensibilities, or some other axis of real diversity.
2. Group work for 20 minutes.
3. Each group reads its declaration in plenary, without explaining or justifying it.
4. On the board or sheet, identify the convergences among the different groups' declarations.
5. *Optional*: attempt to distill a shared declaration from all the groups, in two or three lines.

Debrief

- Was it easier or harder than you expected?
- What made it to the table by consensus and what did not?
- What does it reveal about the specific contribution of faith communities to the problem addressed?
- Introduce here, if it emerges from the group, the notion of the *ecumenism of doing* (Francis): unity shows itself in contributing together, more than in agreeing beforehand.

Notes for the facilitator

It is normal for the first 5–7 minutes of group work to be slow: participants are calibrating with each other. It is worth walking by the tables and helping unstick with a short question when one gets bogged down. What is pastorally powerful happens in the last 10 minutes: when each group realizes that it *can* write a shared declaration, and does.

CROSS-CUTTING ADVICE — CLOSING ROUND

Any of the three activities above gains depth if closed with the same **brief round**, with a talking piece and a single prompt:

*“What did I take away about doctrine
that I did not know when I came in?”*

This question makes individual learning visible and, in most groups, gives the facilitator the material for the final summary of the session.

Practical guidelines

- The facilitator **does not comment or validate** each contribution during the round. Only holds the rhythm.
- The round is not a place for debate or crossed questions. Each person receives the piece, says their own, and passes it on.
- Passing is allowed: whoever does not wish to speak passes the piece without justifying. The round may return to that person at the end if they so wish.
- At the close of the round, the facilitator gathers two or three emerging threads from the group. **Only two or three.** The discipline of not saying more is part of the care of the space.
- If the round is at the end of a long day, consider doing it standing, in a closed circle, without chairs. It shifts the bodily register and helps make contributions briefer and more essential.

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